Freak the Geek

By John Green

INTRODUCTION

First off, let me start out by saying being a geek is cool. It's awesome, even. The geeks are the better species. I, for one, take pride in the fact that I am a geek. But unfortunately, almost every geeky kid gets socially ostracized. Almost all get mocked. In fact, almost all face some physical abuse. In fact, at the Hoover Preparatory School for Girls . . . . it's tradition. Freak the Geek by John Green.

Right after our last class, Kayley and I are walking past the only bit of stone wall that survived the epic 1922 fire that nearly destroyed Hoover Preparatory School for Girls. The only redeemable facet of Hoover is Kayley herself, who is about the best baof one could ask for. (Baof meaning, of course, best and only friend; it is the final frontier in friendship, the heady waters out past the Sea of Bff.)

Hoover Preparatory School for Girls has a number of profoundly stupid traditions--such as the

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singing-the-alma-mater-song-every-Thursday-at-lunch tradition, and the stand-when-your-teachers-enter-the-classroom tradition, and the everyone-has-to-wear-the-exact-same-uniform-so-that-no-one-will-beable-to-tell-who-the-geeks-are-except-of-course-everyone-can-tell-who-the-geeks-are-because-geek-isn't-something-you-wear-it-is-something-you-are tradition.

As it happens, I think doing things solely because they were done in the past is absolutely idiotic. I suppose it shows respect to our teachers when we stand every time they come into the room, but you know what would show more respect? If the insolent students who have colonized this awful place paid attention in class. Or took notes.

Witness, for instance, seventh period: AP Physics. In the row before me, Amber and Nataley quietly discuss whose basically identical calf-length white socks are cuter. ("No, yours are," Amber whispers, when Dr. Halfrecht turns around to draw a diagram of how one can measure the speed of light. "No,"

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Nataley mouths silently in response. "Yours are adorable.")

The weirdest things get cool sometimes. This is why I have never taken a lot of stock in 'being' cool (as if popularity is something that inhabits you, permanently, a virus that overwhelms your immune system so completely that you cease to 'be' you; instead you have become cool).

Hoover is all right. But the incessant fetishizing of traditions? Unbearable. And so when someone runs past Kayley and me and whispers "Freak the Geek," I am doubly pissed. First, I am pissed because Freak the Geek is a tradition. And second, I'm pissed because you only hear those words whispered to you when you are one of the geeks who are about to get freaked. I'm not ashamed that I love *Dr. Who*, or that I've read ten thousand pages of HP fanfiction online. I'm not even ashamed about my Pokemon addiction. (Okay, a little.) I like being a geek. But no one--not even the hard-core geeks who have g-e-e-k tattooed on their knuckles--wants to be one of THE geeks.

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Kayley and I wheel around simultaneously, trying to identify the whisperer. But she's already several paces away, just a narrow-hipped body with a blond ponytail bobbing around. She could be any of us, really. And that's the idea, I guess: Freak the Geek is the one day each year when everybody at Hoover gets to be One of Us--except, I suppose, for Kayley and me. I feel weirdly embarrassed, like I've disappointed the universe by failing to claw far enough out of the social-caste basement to escape whatever humiliation awaits.

We know the drill, because we've seen geeks Freaked our freshman and sophomore years. The entire class gets together and on a chosen day in the second semester of junior year, they pick two geeks to Freak. Freaking takes various forms, of course: They might drag you by the ankles to the pond and throw you in, or they might egg your car with three hundred eggs.

Kayley and I don't say anything; we just take off sprinting toward my car. I figure it's our best chance. But when we get within view of the parking lot, I see

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fifty girls standing in concentric rings around my SUV. Each of them appears to be holding a gun.

"Jesus, Lauren," she mumbles under her breath to me, "have they renamed it Kill the Geek?" One of them raises her weapon toward us. It's a strange-looking gun, with a pink handle and an exceptionally long barrel. I'm pretty sure it doesn't shoot bullets, but even so I dive for the ground and cover my head. Kayley just stands there, and when I look up at her, she's shaking her head. "Paintballs?!" she shouts.

"Paintballs?! The whole world of mischief and malfeasance is available to you and you pick PAINTBALLS?! You disappoint me, ladies." The sound is a loud puff of air. Kayley doesn't even flinch when a splatter of scarlet red paint bursts a foot away from her head against one of our campus's famed live oaks.

We take off running together, away from the parking lot toward the lacrosse practice field. I don't hear any more paintball firings as I race across Hoover Green. I want to run back toward the classrooms, because surely someone will help. I mean, the

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administration has no official policy on Freak the Geek because they love traditions too much to denounce any of them, but they wouldn't let this happen to us. But Kayley grabs me, steering me toward the woods. "We just need a teacher," I say. I can hear them behind me, some girl shouting, "Switch to automatic mode, Scarlet Ballers!" Kayley swivels around and starts running backward long enough to shout, "You call yourselves the Scarlet Ballers and *we're* the geeks?"

Kayley shouts, "Lauren, come on. Fast." We're almost across the lacrosse field now, a thick stand of trees before us, and the Freakers must have terrible aim or else paintball guns are hard to shoot, because the trees are soon riddled with abstract paintings in red, but nothing's hit me yet and then finally we're in among the trees.

And here is our advantage: The Freakers might be in better physical shape than us, but no one knows these woods like Kayley and me. We've been walking around the hundreds of acres of forest on Hoover's campus for three years' worth of lunch periods. Both

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the food and the atmosphere at the cafeteria are unbearable, and anyway, we've never really gotten along terribly well with the girls who eat there--which is to say all of them.

"I never really thought about it before," I tell Kayley as we simultaneously duck under a low-hanging oak branch, "but just the phrase 'Freak the Geek' is just hugely lame."

By the time we crest the hill, I can't even hear the Freakers anymore. I feel good. I wish they hadn't picked us. There are plenty of unpopular people to go around--the drama kids who do the tech work, the girl who single-handedly runs the student newspaper, the girls who Kayley and I play Pokemon with in the student lounge during free periods--but if they had to pick us, at least they've picked BOTH of us.

We descend the other side of the hill, headed toward the cemetery where the school founder and her family are buried. I know we're near the bottom when I hear Hoover Creek.

"The bridge," I say.

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Kayley and I had spent many lunches under the bridge--the cement outcropping lets us sit with our legs dangling over the water, which ran loud enough to muffle our voices to anyone walking or driving above, but quiet enough that we could always hear each other. I reach the bridge a couple minutes later and sit down next to Kayley, who is staring into the water.

She doesn't say anything to me, so after a while, I tell her, "I feel kinda like an ork, hiding out under a bridge."

"A troll," she says, and then sighs. "You feel kinda like a troll."

"No, trolls are people. I don't feel like a person. I feel like an ork," I insist.

She sighs again, this time clearly annoyed. "Lauren," she says. "You're so stupid sometimes. Trolls are not people. Orks are not people. Only humans are people. Orks are from Tyrol folklore, and they live on mountains. Trolls live under bridges. And they have really long hair and big noses, and that's clearly what you mean when you say ork."

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I reach over and put my hand on her shoulder and say, "Okay. Sorry. I meant trolls. Jeez, are you okay?"

"Yeah, Lauren, I'm splendid. Everyone in my entire class is trying to attack me with paintball guns, and I've officially been declared one of the two least liked people in my peer group, and my best friend doesn't know crap about folklore, and I'm dirty and sweaty and gross and just *splendid*."

"Well, you don't have to be bitchy," I say. "It's not my fault."

She says nothing.

"It's not my fault," I repeat, and she says nothing, and then smaller, I say, "You think..."

She takes that as a start. "I think that sometimes you can be a little...I don't know. Meek. And they prey on that. So they prey on us."

I just stand up and climb out from under the bridge. Maybe what bothers me so much is the thought that Kayley might be right, but mostly I'm just furious with her for even thinking that, let alone saying it out loud.

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"Where are you going?" she asks.

"To the car," I say as I walk away. I'm talking so softly she probably can't even hear me. "All things being equal, I would rather be paintballed."

I'm walking for about thirty seconds when I hear Kayley's footfalls behind me. "I'm sorry," she says.

I wheel around. "You know, you're a total know-it-all. And it's incredibly rude sometimes; I mean, you're not perfect either, and you act like it's my fault but it's not my fault for being quiet or your fault for being a know-it-all. It's not your problem or my problem; it's their problem. They're the demented ones, not us, so don't take it out on me, because the only thing that holds anything together for me is having someone else on the Not Demented Team."

Kayley just nods, and then we stand there for a second, and then she hugs me. She says, "I'm sorry," and I can hear her crying in her voice a little. "For now, let us return to your car."

By the time we make it to the car, in the gray twilight, I've forgotten our fight entirely in a way that

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the Freakers never forget their fights, because their fights are all they have. The Freakers have gone home, their cars all disappeared from the parking lot.

There's a single lipstick-red splotch of paintball goo on the front grill of my car. It doesn't wash off for months, but I don't mind. It is not my scarlet letter. It's theirs.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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